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Human Voices and Algorithmic Echoes: Resignifying Transfeminine Experiences Through Hybrid Poetics Framework

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ABSTRACT

Advances in generative artificial intelligence (AI) are reshaping cultural production, yet questions remain about whether machine-authored texts can authentically represent marginalized lives. This study examines the capacity of OpenAI's GPT-4o to represent the lived experiences of transfeminine individuals using a three-phase Hybrid Poetics Framework (HPF). Ten transfeminine participants were recruited through purposive maximum variation sampling. Semi-structured interviews and a participatory focus group (FGD-1) informed the creation of both human-generated poems (HGPs) and AI-generated poems (GPT-4o poems). In the reception phase, participants completed an authorship discrimination task and poetic quality ratings, followed by a structured poetry-reflection focus group (FGD-2). Results show that participants identified authorship above chance and rated HGPs higher for Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, and Structural Quality, while AI poems were praised for polish but perceived as emotionally distant. By contrast, creativity showed overlap across conditions.Findings foreground authenticity, affective fidelity, and ethical risks in AI-mediated representation. We propose bounded legibility and community co-governance as safeguards and introduce the Hybrid Poetics Framework (HPF) as a methodological approach for operationalizing participatory evaluation in Human Computer Interaction (HCI).

KEYWORDS

AI poetry; human-generated poems; hybrid poetics framework; transfeminine; human–computer interaction

1. Framing poetic machines

> Technology is not neutral. We're inside of what we make, and it's inside of us. We're living in a world of connections, and it matters which ones get made and unmade. (Haraway, 1991, p. 149)

Advancements in Artificial Intelligence (AI) are reshaping contemporary discourse and raising urgent ethical and philosophical questions at the intersection of human identity and machine-generated art. The integration of AI into poetry, a genre intrinsically tied to human emotion, cultural context, and lived experience, invites deeper interrogation of its capacity to reflect and reconfigure the complexities of human existence. In an increasingly algorithm-mediated world, a pivotal question emerges: Can AI authentically capture the nuanced, often visceral realities of marginalized communities, or does it merely mimic surface-level esthetics of human expression?

This study examines the role of OpenAI's GPT-4o in generating poetic representations of the lived experiences of transfeminine individuals in Kerala, a region celebrated for its progressive indicators yet marked by tensions between modernity and normative gendered subjectivity (Osella & Osella, 2000). In recent years, Kerala's public sphere has seen a discursive shift in which "gender politics" is cast as a public threat, mobilizing heterogeneous coalitions and turning trans-queer bodies and educational spaces into battlegrounds; in this configuration, anti-gender politics operates as a (pseudo) intellectual frame for social conservatism that resignifies "gender" to delegitimize

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trans-queer advances (Vadakka Chandran (Riza), 2025). Transfeminine individuals, identifying with femininity rather than their assigned gender at birth, navigate complex social terrains shaped by marginalization and stigma. Drawing from Judith Butler's (1988) assertion that "gender is a performance with clearly punitive consequences" (p. 522), this research situates transfeminine lives within the socio-cultural and political frameworks of Kerala, exploring how AI might mediate their stories. The authors propose the Hybrid Poetics Framework (HPF), employing poetic inquiry to both examine and re-present participants' narratives, rendering them into poems authored by humans and by GPT-4o. Focus groups then evaluated these poems through a participatory approach combining qualitative reflection and quantitative ratings. While computational creativity has garnered increasing attention, existing research often overlooks the socio-cultural dimensions of AI-generated content. Moreover, the voices of marginalized groups are frequently excluded from the datasets and frameworks underpinning AI systems. By centering transfeminine narratives from Kerala, this paper makes three contributions. First, the paper introduces the Hybrid Poetics Framework (HPF) as an integrative methodological approach, rather than a general theory of AI creativity or representation. HPF functions as a research design scaffold that combines poetic inquiry, AI-mediated text generation, and participatory reception to structure this study's comparative inquiry. It provides a structured yet reflexive way to elicit, transform, and evaluate marginalized lived experiences across human- and AI-authored texts, while attending to questions of authorship, affect, and ethical representation. Second, within this framework, the study advances a mixed-methods evaluative apparatus by adapting authorship discrimination experiments and qualitative poetic quality ratings into a four-parameter rubric for assessing AI-generated poetry. This contribution is supported by full prompt provenance and an output-fixed protocol, enabling transparent comparison between human-generated and GPT-4o poems. Alongside this, the paper articulates the principle of bounded legibility to temper the impulse to render marginalized lives fully machine-readable and documents practical safeguards for ethical AI usage in creative research. Third, for Human-Computer Interaction (HCI), the paper positions poetry as an experience-prototyping surface through which the affective, ethical, and political dimensions of generative systems can be examined. It offers transferable guidance for designing, evaluating, and governing creativity support systems with and for marginalized communities. Throughout the paper, we use the term "framework" in a pragmatic sense to denote a structured methodological design, rather than a standalone theoretical or explanatory model.

2. Poetic inquiry and its evolution

Poetic inquiry is an arts-based methodological approach that emerged as a response to critiques of conventional qualitative research practices (Furman et al., 2006; Glesne, 1997; Prendergast, 2004; Richardson, 2001). It utilizes poetry to interpret qualitative data, capturing the emotional, experiential, and relational dimensions of participants lived experiences (McCulliss, 2013; Prendergast et al., 2009). Originating in the 1970s, Poetic inquiry was driven by multiculturalists and feminists advocating for the inclusion of diverse voices and ways of knowing in qualitative research (Faulkner, 2009). Early proponents such as Carl Leggo, Patricia Leavy, Sandra Faulkner, and Monica Prendergast laid the groundwork for its recognition within qualitative research and its growth in higher education.

Unlike literary poetry, which may integrate imaginative elements or alter original experiences, research poetry[1] is rooted in accurately conveying the core truths of their source materials (Faulkner, 2009; Furman et al., 2007). Its adaptability allows for application in various contexts, from analyzing social-ecological dynamics in natural resource management (Fernández-Giménez et al., 2019) to exploring sensitive topics in healthcare through duoethnographic poetry (Breckenridge & Clark, 2017). Moreover, the evolution of poetic inquiry has seen it develop into a critical tool for decolonizing qualitative research, allowing to disrupt hierarchical knowledge production and foster epistemologies that embrace interconnectedness and subjectivity (Green et al., 2021; Wu, 2021). It is these qualities of inclusivity, emotional resonance, and capacity to capture lived experience that make poetic inquiry particularly suited to exploring the experiences of sexual and gender minority groups.

Rather than a linear pipeline, poetic inquiry unfolds in iterative loops of analysis and composition: coding and condensation, followed by poetic crafting (lineation, imagery, voice), and then participant feedback and revision. Scholars have mobilized this approach in justice-oriented research designs that amplify marginalized voices while resisting Eurocentric epistemologies. For example, Davis (2023) integrates poetic inquiry with critical race theory to analyze spoken-word performances by young poet-activists, tracing civic identities grounded in cultural pride, resistance, and community-based activism. Similarly, other researchers have drawn on ancestral oral traditions and nonlinear storytelling to center community epistemologies: Tuwe (2018) uses African proverb-based circular narrative to explore migrant employment in New Zealand; and Glyal (2025) analyses Joy Harjo's cyclical, mythic poetic forms as sites of cultural resilience. Collectively, these examples illustrate the methodological flexibility and cultural responsiveness of poetic inquiry, reaffirming its value in research contexts where identity, heritage, and resistance are central. Poetic inquiry has also been effectively utilized to document the lived realities of transgender individuals. For instance, Van Rooyen et al. (2021) explored the lived experiences of 15 transwomen in Namibia using poetic inquiry, creating "found poems" from focus group discussions to capture issues like identity, violence, agency, and belonging. This process of collaborative poetics, producing poems from data and offering them back to participants for reflection, challenges the role of the researcher by shifting away from traditional approaches of describing culture through their own schemes and categories (Brueggeman, 1996). In this study, we build on poetic inquiry but operationalize it through an author-developed Hybrid Poetics Framework (HPF) that links three phases: Narrativization, Textualization, and Reception. This framework integrates coauthored human poems and output-fixed GPT-4o poems with a reception phase centered on collaborative poetics. In doing so, it foregrounds our epistemological stance that values affective, culturally situated, and justice-oriented knowledge production.

3. AI in computational creativity

Recent scholarship in computational creativity demonstrates how generative language models have reshaped creative production, with large language models (LLMs) achieving increasingly human-like fluency in language and artistic expression. LLMs such as OpenAI's GPT − 3 (Brown et al., 2020) and Meta's Llama (Ragot et al., 2020; Touvron et al., 2023) leverage training on massive text corpora, enabling the generation of outputs whose coherence and stylistic control increasingly resemble human authorship. In some instances, the outputs of these AI systems are virtually indistinguishable from human-written texts, highlighting the extraordinary progress in natural language generation and its potential to redefine creative expression (Clark et al., 2021; Elgammal et al., 2017; Jakesch et al., 2023). AI's capabilities extend beyond text generation, with studies by Sun et al. (2022) revealing that AI-generated paintings are often judged as human-created at higher rates than actual human-made artworks. Similarly, Miller et al. (2023) and Ragot et al. (2020) found that AI-generated faces are more frequently perceived as real human faces compared to authentic photographs of humans and Gorenz and Schwarz (2024) demonstrate that AI-generated humor has been shown to rival the comedic appeal of jokes crafted by humans.

Poetry, as a literary genre, resists strict formal conventions and embraces a degree of arbitrariness, making it particularly difficult to interpret and evaluate (Linardaki, 2022). AI-generated poetry often struggles with meaningfulness and "poeticness," a term capturing the aesthetic and emotional resonance of poems (Manurung, 2003). Early models, such as Theo Lutz's (1959) "Stochastic Texts," marked the beginning of algorithmic poetry, focusing on syntactic structure rather than semantic depth. Over subsequent decades, an "affective turn" moved beyond pure syntax, wherein sentiment-aware systems sought emotional tone (Misztal-Radecka & Indurkhya, 2014), while neural pipelines using recurrent neural network[2] (RNN) based framework and attention, improved thematic coherence and continuity (Yan, 2016; Yi et al., 2017). In parallel, Lau et al. (2018) introduced Deep-speare, a composite neural network model to generate quatrains in the style of Shakespearean sonnets,[3] achieving structural accuracy but revealing limitations in readability and coherence. Taken together, these advances show steady gains in surface fluency and formal control but leave open the central problem of cultural specificity and lived affect.

Despite these advancements, poetry demands a depth of creativity and meaning that AI-generated text, being devoid of lived experience, struggles to authentically replicate (Elam, 2023). For instance, Liu et al. (2018) conducted a Turing Test[4] to assess the ability of human participants to distinguish between AI-generated and human-written poems inspired by images. Both literature experts[5] and novices exhibited high confusion rates (40–57%), with experts slightly outperforming novices. In contrast, Köbis and Mossink (2021) explored individuals' ability to distinguish between GPT-2 generated poems and those written by Maya Angelou and Hermann Hesse. Results showed that participants failed to reliably detect the algorithmically generated poems in the human-in-the-loop condition,[6] yet succeeded in the human-out-of-the-loop condition.[7] Similar challenges have been observed more broadly, as non-expert participants often struggle to reliably differentiate between AI-generated and human-written poems, with accuracy rates sometimes falling below chance levels, despite biases against AI authorship (Porter & Machery, 2024). Additionally, methodologies such as neural style transfer[8] have been applied to textual data, allowing AI to adopt the stylistic features of specific authors or poetic traditions (Ghazvininejad et al., 2017). Although Linardaki's (2022) survey highlights the successes of computational creativity in generating poetry, it also underscores the mixed ability of non-experts to distinguish between AI-generated and human-written works. Non-experts often rely on cues unrelated to the structural subtleties of rhyme and meter, which limits their evaluative precision (Gunser et al., 2022; Rahmeh, 2023). The capabilities of AI in producing poetry extend beyond mimicking syntax and style; they encompass capturing thematic depth and emotional resonance.

The challenge lies not only in training models to capture linguistic patterns, but also in ensuring sensitivity to the socio-cultural contexts that shape human expression (Veale & Cook, 2018). AI systems trained on vast datasets often reproduce embedded cultural prejudices (Jobin et al., 2019), reinforcing stereotypes and discrimination against marginalized groups (Bolukbasi et al., 2016). Without contextual understanding, outputs risk being insensitive, harmful, or reductively oversimplified (Birhane, 2021). Recent studies underscore these dangers: Hofmann et al. (2024) identify covert prejudice against African American Vernacular English in LLMs, while Mire et al. (2025) show reward models systematically penalizing African American Language. At the user level, Basoah et al. (2025) document how Black writers find AI tools simultaneously stylistically useful yet culturally alienating, echoing Helm et al.'s (2024) account of techno-linguistic bias that structurally excludes non-dominant languages. Broader evaluations, such as Mitchell et al.'s (2025) SHADES dataset, reveal how AI spreads stereotypes across languages and cultures, and Kay et al. (2025) extend this by showing that while memorization of human biases and the fabrication of falsehoods remain rampant issues in generative AI, these systems can also be re-engineered to surface injustices and promote epistemic justice as a principle of equity. Barry and Stephenson (2025) further demonstrate how generative AI entrenches both epistemic and hermeneutical injustice, reinforcing structural power imbalances that marginalize non-dominant voices across online and offline contexts. Furthermore, Parks (2025) shows how AI, particularly in healthcare and language systems, can exacerbate discrimination at the intersection of transgender identity and neurodivergence, warning that without parallel reforms in legal frameworks and stronger commitments to intersectional inclusion, even technically sophisticated interventions risk being undermined by structural and policy constraints. Addressing these limitations requires approaches that foreground both context and collective power.

Foundational frameworks like feminist HCI methodology (Bardzell & Bardzell, 2011) and consent ethics (Metcalf et al., 2016) remain crucial because they foreground gender, power, and agency in technology design, offering the baseline principles of fairness and participant protection. More recent work builds on these principles, deepening them through intersectional and community-led perspectives. Attard-Frost (2025) introduces transfeminist AI governance, advocating for ethics rooted in participatory power and justice. The concept of epistemic autonomy also advances a transfeminine-informed HCI paradigm that foregrounds narrative sovereignty and participant knowledge (Ajmani et al., 2025). Concerns about trust are especially salient in domains such as personalized medicine, where trans communities' express unease about the opacity and risks of AI-driven systems (Buslón et al., 2025). At the same time, LGBTQ+ representation within HCI research remains limited, with calls for more inclusive design practices that reflect diverse identities and lived experiences (Taylor et al., 2024). Taken together, these contributions indicate a shift toward relational, community-governed, and justice-oriented

approaches to design. It is within this context, we introduce the HPF that integrates poetic inquiry with participatory HCI across three phases (Narrativization, Textualization, and Reception), under governance principles of bounded legibility, prompt provenance, and community co-governance.

4. Recruitment process and data collection

A total of 10 transfeminine participants were recruited using a purposive sampling approach to ensure inclusion of individuals with directly relevant lived experiences (Palinkas et al., 2015). Recruitment used an integrative, end-to-end workflow to map diversity axes, purposively maximizing variation, auditing heterogeneity iteratively, and stopping at meaning saturation (Ahmad & Wilkins, 2025). This was also guided by an intersectional positioning lens to balance individual depth with group coverage (Bouncken et al., 2025). To capture the breadth of perspectives necessary for poetic inquiry, the study employed maximum variation sampling (MVS). Participants were intentionally selected to represent a wide spectrum of caste, class, educational attainment, occupational status, and urban-rural residence, as well as activist and non-activist backgrounds, varying degrees of family acceptance, and different stages in their gender identity journey. This diversity enhanced the poetic co-construction process by bringing a variety of emotional registers, cultural contexts, and life histories into the dataset. MVS also enabled the identification of recurring thematic patterns that persisted despite demographic differences, thus surfacing core or central experiences within the broader transfeminine community (Patton, 1990). In keeping with the study's commitment to inclusivity, internal heterogeneity was treated as a strength rather than a confounding factor. A falsification method was employed during analysis, whereby outlier narratives were retained and critically examined to test and refine emerging thematic claims (Popper, 1959). This approach strengthened internal generalizability and supported analytic generalization of theoretical insights into other socio-cultural contexts (Maxwell & Chmiel, 2014). The empirical validation component of the reception phase involved the original transfeminine participants (non-expert readers). This aligns the study with everyday audience reception and limits bias from expert heuristics (e.g., form-centric scoring or genre expectations). Non-expert judgment provided a conservative, ecologically valid test of perceived authorship and poetic quality in the typical reading conditions.

Participants represented a broad spectrum of Kerala's transfeminine community. Their lived experiences of gender affirmation or transfeminine identification spanned different phases of life, including pre- and post-transition. The sample included individuals from Dalit, Adivasi, and OBC communities as well as from dominant caste groups. Educational attainment varied: two participants had completed only primary education, two had discontinued secondary school, three held higher secondary qualifications, one held a bachelor's degree in humanities and two held master's degrees. Occupational statuses reflected both formal and informal labor sectors and included sex workers, domestic workers, NGO staff, self-employed performance artists, and unemployed individuals. While the study purposively included participants from diverse caste, occupational, and educational backgrounds, it did not attempt to correlate these demographic variables (such as caste, religion, age, or urban/rural location) with thematic patterns in the data. This decision was both epistemological and ethical. First, the study's primary objective was not to produce statistically generalizable claims across social subgroups, but rather to foreground affective, narrative, and symbolic dimensions of transfeminine life as expressed through poetic inquiry. Second, the relatively small sample size, typical of qualitative work, does not support robust demographic cross-analysis without risking reductive interpretations. Finally, centering caste or religion as categorical determinants risked reinscribing the very social stratifications this research seeks to problematize. That said, this focus on thematic depth over demographic breadth may be seen as a limitation; future studies could adopt a comparative or stratified design to further examine how caste, religion, or regionality mediate transfeminine subjectivity in different ways.

Data collection involved semi-structured interviews and two focus group discussions (FGDs) conducted over the study period from May 2024 to August 2024. The research followed established qualitative protocols for participatory data generation (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Creswell & Poth, 2018). In-depth semi-structured interviews were conducted with each participant in three stages. Each interview lasted between 60 to 90 min and took place in private comfortable settings chosen by the participants, with six conducted face-to-face and four held online to accommodate participants' preferences and availability.

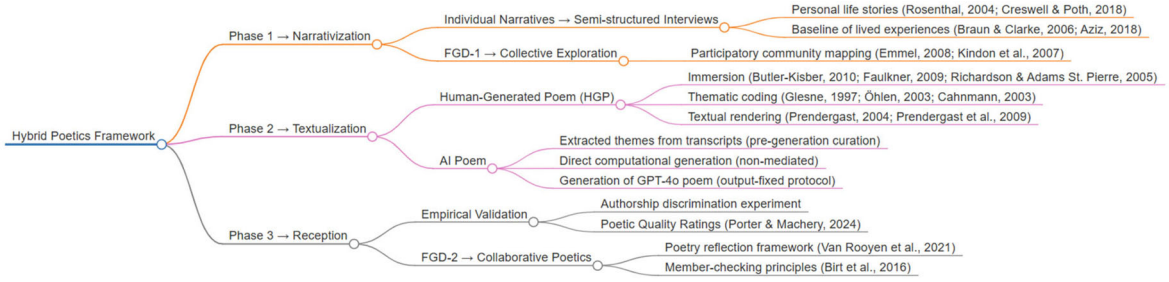


Figure 1. Hybrid poetics framework (HPF).

5. Hybrid poetics framework (HPF)

This study adopted HPF (Figure 1), developed by the authors, structured across three phases: Narrativization, Textualization, and Reception. Each phase combined established qualitative techniques, with the exception of generation of AI Poems, which were generated directly through pre-curated and a fixed GPT-4o output protocol. Together, these phases created an iterative process in which narratives were first elicited through semi-structured interviews and FGD-1, then textualized into human and AI-authored poems and finally evaluated through empirical validation and collaborative poetics (FGD-2). This integration ensured that poetic outputs were grounded in participant experience and feedback.

5.1. Phase one: Narrativization

This phase focused on eliciting participants' lived experiences through semi-structured interviews and collective exploration exercise (FGD-1) that followed established guidance for qualitative interviewing and study conduct (Creswell & Poth, 2018). During the semi-structured interviews, participants were invited to offer a spontaneous narration of their life story in response to an open-ended prompt modeled on life-history approaches (Rosenthal, 2004). Follow-up questions were then posed, based on specific details shared by the participant. The final stage includes externally framed questions developed prior to the interview, encouraging the participant to reflect and abstract their experiences (Aziz, 2018; Rosenthal, 2004). An interview guide was used to steer conversations, while preserving openness to emergent topics (Braun & Clarke, 2006; Creswell & Poth, 2018). All participants provided informed consent. Interviews were audio-recorded and transcribed verbatim. To protect privacy, we used pseudonyms and removed identifying details. Researchers engaged in reflexivity throughout the study by maintaining reflective journals, debriefing after each interview session, and discussing how their own social positions in relation to gender, religion, caste, and language might shape the research process and interpretation of narratives.

To extend individual narratives into a collective exploration, we convened FGD − 1 as a group exercise shaped by themes that surfaced in the interviews. The session opened with a participatory community mapping exercise (Emmel, 2008), where participants were invited to draw representations of their communities and identify spaces perceived as safe or unsafe. The concept of "community" emerged in relation to visibility, access to public spaces such as temples, beaches, bus and railway stations, and parks; safety in rented accommodations; access to local clinics and government hospitals; and the dynamics of intimate partner relationships. These dynamics were voiced by participants:

> After dark the road to my room becomes a corridor of warnings; bike headlights, whistles, 'are you alone?' - so I walk with keys in my fist. When I reported the men who followed me, the constable said, go home earlier. (Anjali, 26yo)

> In the temple queue a woman whispered, 'what is it?' and the priest told me to stand aside. I am watched and recognised as a problem, not as a person. (Nila, 30yo)

Participants situated their narratives within the realities of Kerala's deeply patriarchal society, highlighting systemic issues of casteism, gender normativity, restricted autonomy, and violations of personhood. These trajectories echo how gendered modernity organizes public/private space and respectability (Devika, 2007), how gender politics and moral policing regulate visibility in public spaces, and how

sexuality is governed through surveillance and shame in everyday spaces (Mokkil, 2019). Bureaucratic regimes further intensify exclusion, especially for those outside normative gender scripts, while state policy itself acknowledges persistent discrimination and sets out remedial measures. Within this context, sexual silences persist, and autonomy is negotiated through closeting performances that erode personhood through shame, surveillance, and social sanction (Dev & Joy, 2025). These accounts reflected all three dimensions of inequality outlined in Göran Therborn's (2013) framework of existential inequalities. Vital inequalities emerged in threats to bodily safety and integrity through experiences of moral policing, harassment in public spaces, and denial of nondiscriminatory healthcare. Existential inequalities appeared in the form of symbolic erasure, public shaming, surveillance, and the persistent denial of dignity across intersections of caste, gender identity, and religion. Resource inequalities were evident in restricted access to secure livelihoods, educational opportunities, and fair treatment in public institutions, disproportionately affecting lower-caste and transfeminine individuals residing in rural areas. Participants recounted experiences of macroaggression[9] in daily life across government offices, public healthcare institutions, educational settings, and other civic spaces. The conduct of power holders, including law enforcement officers and representatives of religious groups, was described as contributing to exclusion, surveillance, and moral policing. Together, these layered accounts underscored the structural nature of marginalization in participants' everyday lives and provided the narrative foundation for the textualization phase.

5.2. Phase two: Textualization

The second phase textualized the narrative and collective accounts generated in phase-one into poetic form, combining human-centered and AI-mediated approaches. This stage involved two parallel processes: the drafting of Human-Generated Poems (HGPs) and the production of AI Poems (GPT-4o Poems). The development of the poems followed a three-step process which drew upon immersion practices (Butler-Kisber, 2010; Faulkner, 2009; Richardson & Adams St. Pierre, 2005), thematic coding of transcripts (Cahnmann, 2003; Glesne, 1997; Öhlen, 2003), and textual rendering methods (Prendergast, 2004; Prendergast et al., 2009) to transform participants' narratives into poetic form.

By contrast, the AI strand employed a protocol devised by the authors and theoretically informed by (Boden, 2016; Colton & Wiggins, 2012; Porter & Machery, 2024), alongside relevant debates on ethics and reception of AI creativity (Tao et al., 2024; Theodorou & Dignum, 2020). Themes were first extracted from transcripts, followed by direct computational generation using GPT-4o under a fixed output protocol. This deliberate separation ensured that AI poems were not mediated through researcher interpretation during generation. Together, these processes operationalized the "textualization" of experience, bridging participant voices and computational creativity, and setting the stage for the empirical validation and collaborative interpretation undertaken in Phase Three.

The Hybrid Poetics Framework (HPF) was developed by the authors in 2024 and iteratively refined via small formative pilots (n = 3–5) to check feasibility, instructions, and ethical safeguards (member-checking; bounded legibility). These pilots informed procedures only; no pilot material or reader data are analyzed here. The present study is the first full implementation of HPF; we evaluate artifacts and reception produced under HPF rather than validating the framework as a psychometric instrument.

5.2.1. Developing HGPs

The process began with a close reading of interview transcripts, with two researchers independently open coding the full corpus and then consolidating codes through consensus meetings. We developed an iterative codebook, kept an audit trail and analytic memos, and treated disagreements and outlier accounts as negative cases rather than errors. Themes were defined not by frequency but by patterned meaning in relation to the research question, with Malayalam-English translation decisions resolved collaboratively. Malayalam terms are presented in simplified transliteration without diacritics, italicized on first use, and then used consistently; a participant-approved glossary is provided in Appendix D. The core themes were gender identity and sexuality, self-acceptance, transitioning, violence, agency, and love. Violence emerged prominently, with participants recounting physical and verbal abuse; transitioning captured internal and social processes of inhabiting gender; and self-acceptance traced struggles

with internalized transphobia and the pursuit of authenticity. Illustrative quotations anchor each theme, and resonance was later member-checked in FGD-2.

The affective strain threaded through the self-acceptance theme is voiced in Anjali's reflection:

> Even now, I look in the mirror and wonder; am I real to them, or just a phase? Sometimes I believe them more than I believe myself. (Anjali, 26yo)

In Kerala, this doubt is patterned by a well-documented paradox; egalitarian developmentalism coexists with durable caste and gender hierarchies, yielding a public that celebrates progress while policing difference (Devika, 2010). In this setting, the excerpt's oscillation between self-knowledge and social recognition is legible: external doubt saturates self-understanding because recognition is unevenly distributed. Viewed through Nancy Fraser's (2000) "*politics of recognition*," the refusal to grant authenticity is misrecognition with profound consequences for personhood. From a trans phenomenological perspective, the notion of "reality enforcement" underscores how being told one is "not real" constitutes epistemic violence (Bettcher, 2014). Together, the participant's testimony cannot be reduced to an individual psychological struggle but instead emerges from interlocking structures of recognition, affect, and embodiment.

After initial reading, the data was collaboratively coded and categorized, extracting excerpts, phrases, and expressions that best encapsulated these experiences. In the second phase, the themes were refined focusing on the technical arrangement and flow of the lines, and poems were drafted by preserving the original meaning and context (Johnson et al., 2017). Participant voices were authentically retained, reflecting unique rhythms, pauses, syntax, and diction (Öhlen, 2003). We introduced a small number of bridging words for grammar and flow, applying "poetic license" (Butler-Kisber, 2010) to re-sequence and, where useful, repeat or omit words while preserving meaning and voice. Poetic devices such as repetition, pauses, line length, and spacing were also employed to enhance and amplify the meaning of the original data (Öhlen, 2003). The human-generated poems (HGPs) were authored by the researchers; Silpa Joy (SJ) and Neerej Dev (ND). The authors share regional and linguistic proximity (Kerala; Malayalam-English bilingual) and sustained engagement with the participant community through fieldwork. We chose insider authorship to maximize linguistic, cultural, and affective fidelity. HGP drafting followed a bounded protocol: we re-sequenced lines only and inserted minimal bridging function-words for grammar and flow, without adding content words or altering meaning; member-checking confirmed tone and intent.

One participant described her inner process of transforming pain into resistance:

> They tried to break me with every word. But every insult I turned into a prayer, every slap into a verse in my head. (Joy, 28yo)

This testimony exemplifies resignification, where injurious speech and embodied harm are reworked into empowering expression through affective and creative transformation (Ahmed, 2013; Butler, 2021). The poem functions as a medium that renders pain into a resistant voice. At the same time, the emotional fatigue articulated here reflects affect as socially circulated wherein emotions of suspicion and dismissal projected by others are absorbed into the subject's sense of self (Ahmed, 2013).

In the third step, the poems were edited for brevity and impact, ensuring simplicity without sacrificing depth. An example of the process is depicted in Table 1. in the left column is a relevant part of the

Table 1. Comparison between verbatim transcript and research poem.

Verbatim transcription in dialogue	HGP—Embracing my truth
My *Umma* "mother" … **she doesn't accept me**. It **hurts**, you know? It **pricks me** all the time. I keep thinking about it, imagining, **daydreaming** - the day she **calls me her daughter.** But I know **how hard it is for her**. She always saw me as the **strong one**, the **man of the house**, the **breadwinner**. And now, here I am- **growing my hair,** **wearing *salwar kameez*** "a type of suit, worn especially by Asian women" **and *sarees*** "draped garment" I've become someone she just **cannot recognize**, someone **completely different**, **miles away from what she thought I would be**.	This pricks me forever, within, the disregard of my Umma Often, I daydream the day She accepts me, as her daughter though I can frame how shattered she is the strong, masculine breadwinner of the home, growing hair, wearing salwar kameez and sarees Here I am, an entirely different person Miles apart from her cognition!

interview transcript and on the right is an extract of the HGP. Highlighted, are the words and phrases utilized in the poem, "Embracing My Truth." This method of poetic transcription highlights the collaborative dialogue between participants and researchers, combining thought, emotion, and intuitive creativity (Dekel, 2008). "In the crafting of the poems, a conversation between participant and researcher occurs. Through that conversation, thought, emotion and inner knowledge are evoked in the researcher" (Van Rooyen et al., 2021). The resulting poems bridged scientific and aesthetic knowledge, developing a democratized and emancipatory approach.

5.2.2. Generation of GPT-4o poems

OpenAI's GPT-4o was chosen for its language generation capabilities, particularly in producing creative and contextually relevant text (Berkowitz, 2024). Its ability to process large amounts of data and generate human-like responses makes it suitable for creating poetry based on the participants' narratives (Wiggers et al., 2024). Some participants expressed cautious appreciation for the stylistic coherence of the GPT-4o poems:

> The AI poem surprised me. It felt … polished, almost wise. But maybe that's why I don't fully trust it. (Faith—21yo)

This ambivalent feedback captures both admiration for GPT-4o's literary form and skepticism about its emotional authenticity. In Phase Two, poems were generated using the web interface of OpenAI GPT-4o (model family: GPT-4) (paid personal plan). Only de-identified excerpts from interviews were supplied; full transcripts were never uploaded. All AI generations for this study occurred between July and November 2024. The version string was not exposed in the interface (the session banner displayed "GPT-4o"). Parameters (temperature, top-p, max_tokens, seed) were not user-configurable and thus cannot be reported; platform defaults are assumed. To maintain provenance despite opaque parameters, the team logged for each run: {timestamp; model label ("GPT-4o"); session URL hash; prompt_template_id; excerpt_hash; output_hash}. These hashes permit verification of one-to-one mapping between excerpts, prompts, and outputs without revealing identities.

We first identified salient themes (as in the HGP workflow), then provided GPT-4o with brief, masked excerpts and task instructions to: (i) infer the central themes and (ii) draft a poem that preserves the participant's voice (rhythms, pauses, syntax, diction) while employing common poetic devices (repetition, line breaks, spacing) to enhance affective resonance. Provider-level retention/training settings were not configurable in our setup, and we did not systematically suppress rare attribute combinations; we therefore note a residual re-identification risk (see Section 5.4). Although transcript selection and prompt design were human-mediated, we enforced an output-fixed (no post-editing) protocol: each GPT-4o poem was analyzed exactly as generated, preserving the integrity of subsequent authorship-discrimination and rating tasks. To maximize comparability, a single neutral-lyric prompt template was fixed across all items to preserve between-poem comparability and avoid confounding stylistic variance with authorship effects (see Appendix D). The template was version-controlled and used consistently for all generations. In line with bounded-legibility safeguards, verbatim participant excerpts are not published. In summary, the template requested a short free-verse poem with clear lineation and natural cadence that preserves the speaker's rhythms, pauses, syntax, and diction, while avoiding specific identifiers. This likely amplified formal polish (regular rhythm, universal metaphors) and may have reduced perceived authenticity for some readers. Consequently, findings should be interpreted as perceptions of a specific model-and-prompt configuration, rather than a verdict on "AI poetry" in general.

An example is provided in Table 2, comparing a transcript excerpt with the corresponding GPT-4o Poem, "Beyond the Monsoon Sky: A Ballad."

5.2.3. Ethical use of GPT-4o and data protection

Interview transcripts contained sensitive personal data. Use of GPT-4o was therefore governed by data minimization and purpose limitation: only deidentified excerpts strictly necessary for poem generation were uploaded and used solely for this study's creative and analytic aims. Prompts were submitted via the standard GPT-4o web interface. The interface did not expose any provider-side "no-retention/

Table 2. Comparison between verbatim transcript and GPT-4o poem.

Verbatim transcription in dialogue	GPT-4o Poem—Beyond the monsoon sky: a Ballad
As a child, everything was so simple. I would play all day and laugh with the other kids near my home. Life felt free, like there was no shadow over me. But things started changing when I grew older. By the time I got to high school, everything felt different. People began looking at me differently. It was like the sweetness of life had turned sour. High school was the worst. The emotions were so intense—I just wanted to feel love, to belong like everyone else. But instead, I was mocked. My voice was softer than the others, and they never let me forget it. I was bullied, scorned. Every word they said cut deep, but I kept going. There was this one teacher—she saw me, really saw me. She treated me like a person, gave me hope. She was like a small light in all that darkness.	Once a child amidst play, innocence in her eyes, No shadows of difference, under the wide skies. But as years unfurled like the petals of a flower, The world's colors changed, from sweet to sour. High school brought storms, emotions deep and wild, A yearning for love, the heart of a child. Bullied and scorned for the softness of her voice, Yet, within her, a resilient spirit made its choice. A teacher's hand, amidst the darkness, a light, A beacon of hope in the longest of nights.

no-training" controls, so none were enabled. Low frequency combinations of attributes were not systematically suppressed. Accordingly, despite deidentification, a residual risk of reidentification and context collapse remains. To reduce downstream harms (e.g., surveillance, misclassification, extractive reuse), the study adopted bounded legibility and audience scoped dissemination. Operational safeguards followed the university data management plan: (i) role based access to source files; (ii) storage on encrypted, institutionally managed drives; (iii) local audit logs recording which excerpt was prompted, when, and by whom; and (iv) a no redistribution policy for verbatim prompts and excerpts in public repositories or supplementary materials. Because the interface lacked a configurable "no retention/no training" mode, the provider was treated as a third-party processor. Its internal data handling could not be technically verified; this constraint is noted in the Limitations (see Section 7). To balance transparency and privacy, we publish the verbatim prompt template (placeholders only) in Appendix D rather than any verbatim participant excerpts. Proceeding without provider-side no-retention controls was justified by the study's co-creative and empirical value together with the safeguards listed above and in Appendix A.

Participants were informed that an AI system (GPT-4o) would be used to generate poems from de-identified interview excerpts. They were offered an opt out without penalty and, through follow up communications, received risk information and the option to withdraw AI derived text from analysis or publication. In line with bounded legibility, quotations were disseminated to preserve meaning for intended audiences while withholding details (e.g., places, persons, distinctive combinations) that could enable reidentification, stereotyping, or secondary reuse outside participant control. The benefits of the approach, including the creation of coauthored artifacts for reflection and advocacy and insights into reader judgements of authenticity were judged to outweigh the residual risks, which were mitigated by the safeguards described above and in Appendix A. Where retention or training controls are unavailable, future work should consider additional measures (for example, suppressing rare combinations of attributes, using paraphrase rather than verbatim text, or running local on-premises models) under community governance of what remains deliberately opaque. Because prompts shape aesthetic outcomes, authorship attributions should be read as a joint product of (i) participant language (excerpts), (ii) the prompt, and (iii) the model. Stylistic prompting was held constant (a single "neutral lyric" style) to preserve between poem comparability; accordingly, the findings apply to that prompted style rather than to "AI poetry" in the abstract.

5.3. Phase three: Reception

Phase 3 shifts from making to meaning, testing how audiences receive the poems and then returning those judgments to participants for interpretation. We first run an empirical validation strand: a Turing-style authorship discrimination task and Poetic Quality Ratings on four dimensions (Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, Creativity, Structural Quality), adapted from (Porter & Machery, 2024). We then convene FGD − 2 as Collaborative Poetics, using a structured poetry-reflection framework to unpack high/low scores, surface misreadings, and locate craft choices in lived context (Van Rooyen et al., 2021). Member-checking

principles guide these sessions to ensure participants can confirm, contest, and refine interpretations, strengthening credibility and ethical alignment (Birt et al., 2016). Together, the experimental and dialogic strands triangulate quantitative judgments with community meaning-making, yielding validated, community-governed interpretations of human vs. AI poems. We intentionally used non-expert readers to approximate typical audience reception and avoid systematic bias introduced by poetry specialists (e.g., privileging metrical craft or intertextuality). This keeps the task aligned with our core question on how transfeminine individuals experience human authored and AI poetry.

5.3.1. Empirical validation

To complement the qualitative phases, we added an empirical validation strand comprising two components: (i) Turing-style authorship-discrimination task to test whether readers could identify poem authorship above chance and (ii) Poetic Quality Rating experiment. The design yields N = 10 readers × 20 items = 200 binary judgements. Under a binomial model, the standard error of accuracy is $SE(\hat{p}) = \sqrt{\hat{p}(1-\hat{p})/N}$; at $\hat{p} = 0.62$ this is ≈ 0.034, giving a 95% CI ≈ 0.62 ± 0.067. Mapping 2AFC accuracy to d′ via $d' = \sqrt{2}\ \Phi^{-1}(\hat{p})$ gives $d' \approx 0.61$ with an illustrative CI consistent with our reported estimate, indicating adequate precision to detect modest departures from chance (0.50; $d' = 0$) with interpretable intervals at $N = 200$.

In the authorship-discrimination task, ten participants judged twenty poems (10 HGPs, 10 GPT-4o Poems) presented in fully randomized order with masked authorship and uniform formatting. To limit superficial cues, the poem sets were length-matched on word count and line count at the set level (median difference within ±20%). Within each authorship set, median word and line counts differed by ≤20%; we did not force one-to-one pairings. For every poem, participants recorded a binary judgment (Human vs AI) and a 1–5 confidence rating; a one-sentence justification ("what tipped you off?") was optional. This within-participant, balanced design yielded 200 classifications (100 per class). Because classes were balanced, accuracy = balanced accuracy, and chance = 0.50. We report (i) overall accuracy with exact binomial (Clopper-Pearson) 95% CIs, (ii) a 2 × 2 confusion matrix (True authorship × Participant judgment), and (iii) signal-detection indices-d′ (discriminability) and criterion c (response bias; c > 0 indicates a tendency to answer "Human")—using a log-linear (Hautus) correction with bootstrap 95% CIs. Accuracy CIs used the exact Clopper-Pearson method with $n = 200$ trials and $k = 124$ correct classifications. Signal-detection metrics used a log-linear (Hautus) correction by adding 0.5 to each cell of the 2 × 2 table before computing d' and criterion c. To aid interpretability, AUC was mapped from d' as $\mathrm{AUC} = \Phi\left(d'/\sqrt{2}\right)$. Bootstrap CIs (95%) for d' and c used $B = 10,000$ resamples with a percentile method and a fixed seed (reported below).

To verify the result, we reanalyzed the data in two ways: (i) a binomial logistic GLM with robust standard errors clustered by participant (Python, statsmodels), and (ii) a logistic mixed-effects model with random intercepts for participant and poem (R, lme4). In both analyses, performance was significantly above the 0.50 chance level. A trial-order term (item index 1–20) was added in a sensitivity model to screen for fatigue/learning. Per-participant accuracy with exact CIs is shown for transparency (see Figures 2 and 3).

Participants discriminated authorship above chance (accuracy = 0.62, 124/200; 95% CI [0.549, 0.688]). Signal-detection analysis indicated modest separability (d′ = 0.61, 95% CI [0.26, 0.96]), which corresponds to an AUC ≈ Φ(d′/√2) ≈ 0.66 were thresholds to vary i.e., moderate ability to distinguish classes. Response bias was negligible (c = −0.13, 95% CI [−0.30, 0.05]). The confusion matrix was asymmetric: HGP→AI = 33 vs GPT-4o→Human = 43, showing that some fluent AI poems were more often promoted to "Human" than HGPs were demoted to "AI" (Figure 2). Both the GLM (cluster-robust) and GLMM (random intercepts for participant and poem) confirmed performance above chance (e.g., intercept OR ≈ 1.63, 95% CI [1.42, 1.88]). The trial-order term was not associated with accuracy ($\beta \approx 0$, $p > 0.10$), suggesting no fatigue/learning trend. Participant-level estimates (exact CIs) showed heterogeneity around the mean—several readers near 0.65–0.70, others near 0.50 (Figure 3). Readers could reliably tell HGP from GPT-4o poems, but with modest sensitivity and minimal bias. Errors clustered where surface fluency and generic imagery made AI poems seem "human," dovetailing with the ratings results (Table 4), where HGPs scored higher on Emotional Quality and Atmosphere

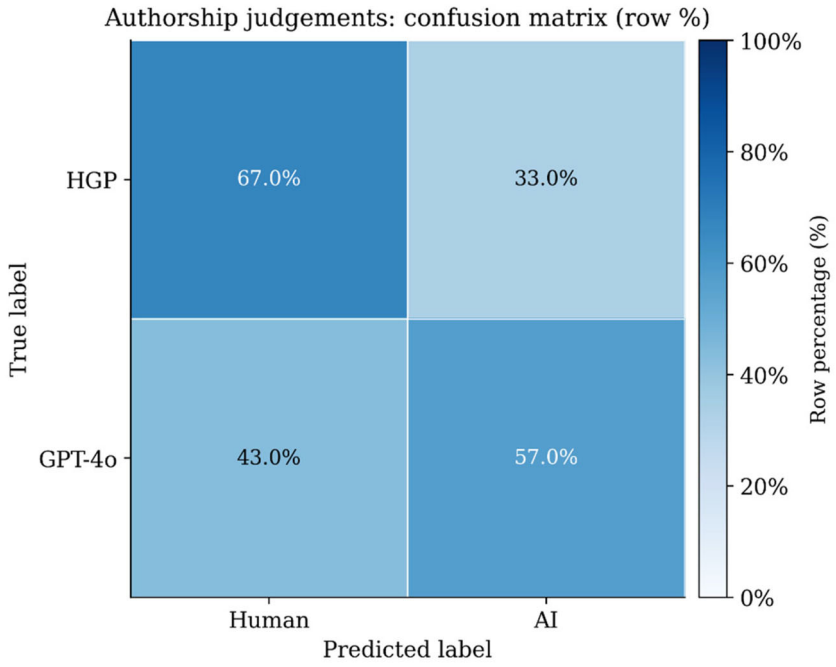


Figure 2. Authorship judgements (row-normalised confusion matrix). True authorship on rows; predicted label on columns; cell values are row percentages (rows sum to 100%). chance performance is 50% for this 2-class task. Counts: HGP→human = 67, HGP→AI = 33; GPT-4o→human = 43, GPT-4o→AI = 57 ($N = 100$ per class; $n = 20$ judgements per participant). SDT metrics are computed from the row-% matrix with log-linear (Hautus) correction.

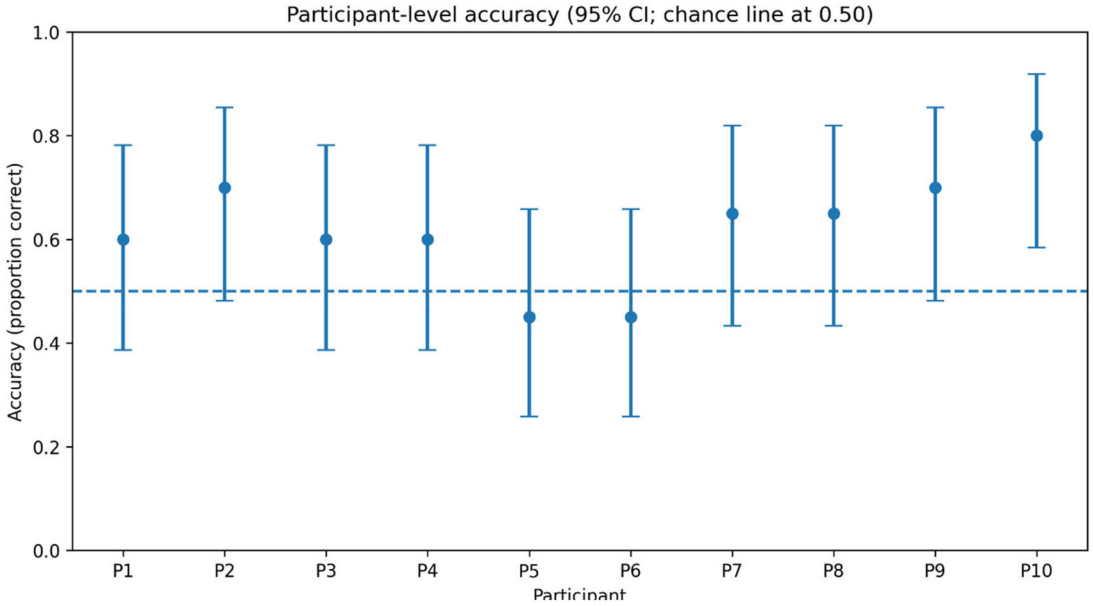


Figure 3. Participant-level accuracy in the authorship discrimination task (human vs AI). Points show each reader's accuracy (proportion correct, 0–1) with 95% exact Clopper-Pearson CIs; the dashed line marks chance = 0.50. $N = 10$ readers, $n = 20$ trials per reader (200 judgements in total).

despite occasional AI "polish." GLM was run in Python (3.11), statsmodels 0.14.1 with cluster-robust (participant-level) standard errors; GLMM used R 4.3.2, lme4 1.1–35.1 with a binomial logit link and optimizer bobyqa (glmerControl(optimizer="bobyqa")). Bootstrap resampling used NumPy 1.26 with a fixed seed (42).

Furthermore, we implemented a Poetic Quality Rating experiment adapted from Porter and Machery (2024). The same 10 participants rated each of the 20 poems on four dimensions intended to capture affective, aesthetic, and technical reception: Emotional Quality (affective resonance/meaningfulness),

Table 3. Rating parameters (adapted from Porter & Machery, 2024).

Parameter	What it captures	Representative cues	Example prompt
Emotional Quality	Affective impact and resonance	beautiful, inspiring, meaningful, moving, profound; overall quality	"How emotionally powerful did this poem feel (e.g., meaningful, moving, beautiful)?"
Atmosphere	Imagery density, thematic clarity, mood evocation	vivid images, clear idea/theme, sustained mood	"How strongly did the poem evoke images/mood and convey a coherent theme?"
Creativity	Perceived originality and inventiveness	original, witty/clever, surprising turns	"How original/creative did the poem feel (e.g., fresh images, unexpected phrasing)?"
Structural Quality	Perceived "craft" of surface form	rhyme/meter or rhythm, line breaks/enjambment, stanza shape, readability/clarity	"How would you rate the poem's craft (rhythm/flow, line breaks, overall readability)?"

Table 4. Linear mixed-effects coefficients (95% CIs) for the four factors and overall quality (composite).

Dependent variable	Emotional quality	Atmosphere	Creativity	Structural quality	Overall quality (composite)
Human Authorship (HGP vs GPT-4o)	0.612** (0.14, 1.08)	0.570** (0.12, 1.01)	0.488* (0.05, 0.92)	0.402* (0.02, 0.78)	0.615** (0.17, 1.06)
Human Framing	0.295 (−0.12, 0.71)	0.215 (−0.20, 0.63)	0.310 (−0.10, 0.72)	0.260 (−0.18, 0.70)	0.298 (−0.15, 0.75)
Authorship × Human Framing	0.180 (−0.20, 0.56)	0.165 (−0.22, 0.54)	0.210 (−0.16, 0.58)	0.190 (−0.21, 0.58)	0.225 (−0.18, 0.62)
Constant	2.95** (2.10, 3.80)	2.88** (2.05, 3.71)	3.10** (2.25, 3.95)	3.05** (2.20, 3.90)	3.00** (2.20, 3.80)
Conditional R^2	0.45	0.43	0.41	0.39	0.47
Marginal R^2	0.22	0.20	0.19	0.18	0.23
Observations	200	200	200	200	200

Random-effects (variance components): participant $\sigma^2_p = \ldots$, poem $\sigma^2_m = \ldots$, residual $\sigma^2_e = \ldots$. Intraclass correlations: $ICC_{participant} = \sigma^2_p/(\sigma^2_p + \sigma^2_m + \sigma^2_e)$, $ICC_{poem} = \sigma^2_m/(\sigma^2_p + \sigma^2_m + \sigma^2_e)$. Conditional and marginal R^2 are reported in the rightmost rows. Note: $^*p < 0.05$, $^{**}p < 0.01$.

Atmosphere (clarity of theme and evocation of mood/imagery), Creativity (originality/surprise), and Structural Quality (craft of surface form—rhythm/flow, lineation, stanza shape, readability). Each dimension was introduced with a plain-language prompt (Table 3) and scored on a 10-point Likert scale (1 = not at all, 10 = extremely). To probe expectation effects, each poem carried a framing cue that was independent of true authorship and randomized at the trial level: Human ("this poem was written by a human"), AI ("this poem was generated by GPT-4o"), or Nothing (no disclosure). Poem order was randomized within participant, and true authorship remained masked. Overall Quality (composite) was computed as the unweighted mean of the four 1–10 ratings (Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, Creativity, Structural Quality) per poem and reader.

Ratings were analyzed with linear mixed-effects models treating the 1–10 scores as continuous. For each outcome (the four factors and Overall Quality (composite)), we estimated fixed effects for Authorship (HGP vs GPT-4o), Framing (Human, AI; reference = Nothing), and their interactions, with random intercepts for participant and poem to account for repeated measures. We fit a linear mixed-effects model to the 1–10 ratings. Each rating y_{ij} (reader i on poem j) was predicted by Authorship (HGP vs GPT-4o), Framing (Human, AI; reference = Nothing), and their interaction, with random intercepts for reader and poem to account for repeated measures. Coefficients are in rating points on the 1–10 scale. We report marginal R^2 (fixed effects only) and conditional R^2 (fixed + random effects). Variance components and intraclass correlations for reader and poem are given in the Table 4 note.

Results (Figure 4; Table 4) showed that Human authorship was a positive predictor across Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, Structural Quality, Creativity, and Overall Quality (composite) with effects on the order of 0.40–0.61 points (all $p < 0.05$). The largest fixed effects were for Emotional Quality ($b = 0.61$, SE = 0.22, $p < 0.01$) and Atmosphere ($b = 0.57$, SE = 0.21, $p < 0.01$), indicating that affective resonance and thematic clarity most strongly differentiated human poems from GPT-4o outputs. Creativity also showed a smaller but reliable advantage for human poems ($b = 0.19$, SE = 0.07, $p < 0.05$), while Structural Quality was significant but comparatively modest ($b = 0.40$, SE = 0.19, $p < 0.05$), suggesting that craft mattered but was not decisive. Framing alone did not reach significance

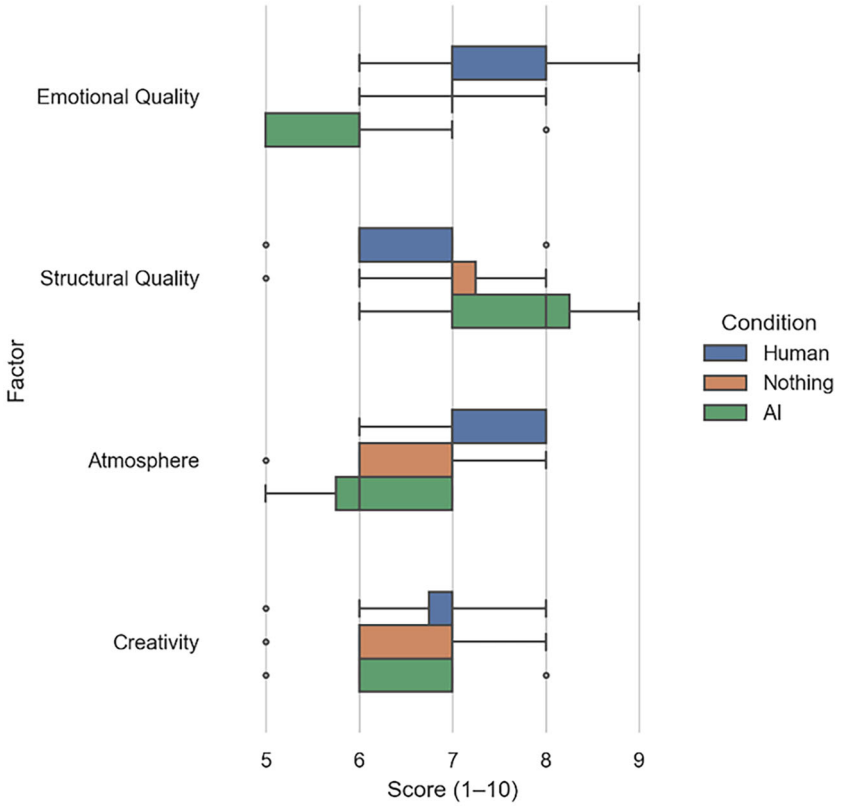


Figure 4. Ratings by factor and condition ($n = 10$ participants). Boxplots show the distribution of 1–10 ratings for each factor across human (HGP), unframed/No label, and AI (GPT-4o) conditions. Factor definitions: Emotional Quality = perceived affective depth/impact; atmosphere = coherence of mood/tone and sense of place; creativity = novelty/originality of images, associations, and phrasing; Structural Quality = craft/organization (lineation, pacing, closure). Medians and IQRs are plotted; outliers shown as points.

(all $p > 0.10$), and Authorship × Framing interactions were not robust, implying that participants' evaluations were driven primarily by intrinsic emotional/atmospheric qualities rather than by stated provenance. Model fit was moderate (conditional $R^2 \approx 0.39$–0.47; marginal $R^2 \approx 0.18$–0.23), indicating meaningful variance explained by the fixed effects together with stable participant/poem differences. Figure 4 visualizes the distribution of scores by factor and framing; medians favor Human framing for Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, and Structural Quality, whereas Creativity shows greater overlap across conditions, consistent with occasional AI novelty.

Accuracy CIs for the authorship task used exact Clopper-Pearson ($n = 200$, $k = 124$). Signal-detection indices used a log-linear (Hautus) correction; AUC was derived from d' as $\mathrm{AUC} = \Phi(d'/\sqrt{2})$. Bootstrap CIs used $B = 10,000$ resamples (percentile; seed = 42). Chance testing used a binomial logistic GLM with cluster-robust SEs by participant (Python, statsmodels). Sensitivity analyses used logistic GLMM with random intercepts for participant and poem (R, lme4). Ratings were analyzed via linear mixed-effects models with random intercepts for participant and poem and fixed effects for Authorship, Framing, and their interaction; marginal/conditional R^2 are reported. Full software versions, optimizers, variance components and ICCs are in Appendix B.

Following the rating exercise, we conducted brief guided discussions in which participants explained especially high or low scores. These narratives were used to triangulate the quantitative ratings and strengthen credibility (Nowell et al., 2017), keeping interpretations anchored in participant-validated meanings while preserving the study's balance of statistical comparability and thematic interpretation. The four-factor rating framework thus functions as a replicable instrument for comparative esthetics in human and computational creativity. All interviews and FGDs were conducted in Malayalam to ensure linguistic familiarity and emotional safety. Audio recordings were transcribed and translated into English by the researchers following recommended practices in cross-language qualitative research to

retain semantic nuance, affective tone, and contextual specificity (Temple & Young, 2004; Van Nes et al., 2010). Translations were independently cross-checked to ensure accuracy and fidelity.

5.3.2. Collaborative poetics

In the collaborative poetics strand, the poems were returned to participants as co-interpretive material. Sessions combined reading aloud with facilitated dialogue and enabling participants to revisit painful memories, voice critique, and articulate hope (Öhlen, 2003; Richardson, 1993, 2001). This format shifted the emphasis from scoring to meaning making, inviting participants to situate the texts within their lived experiences. Poetry thus functioned simultaneously as method and outcome: a vehicle for conveying lived realities and a tangible product through which participants saw themselves reflected, contested, or misrepresented. Human-generated poems (HGPs) often carried cultural and linguistic proximity that participants identified as vital for affective fidelity; GPT-4o poems served as a comparative mirror for interrogating authenticity and distance. For some, HGPs felt raw and visceral, echoing the language of harm and rejection; for others, AI poems appeared polished yet emotionally thinned, raising questions about whether machines can legitimately represent embodied pain. This dual reception highlights poetry's capacity to affirm and empower while also surfacing ethical tensions around authorship, voice, and affective labor. Non-English terms appearing in the discussion follow the same simplified transliteration and glossary conventions (first-use italics + gloss; thereafter consistent spelling; see Appendix C).

To ground interpretation in concrete texts, we include a juxtaposition—Embracing My Truth (HGP by Silpa Joy) and Beyond the Monsoon Sky (GPT-4o poem), that anchored participant reflection (Table 5). The pairing shows a consistent pattern in which participants judged HGPs more authentic due to affective resonance and atmospheric coherence, despite AI poems meeting surface-craft expectations.

The HGP "Embracing My Truth" deeply resonated with the participants, as it vividly encapsulated the pervasive emotional, verbal, physical, and sexual harassment endured. A participant reflected:

> This poem feels raw, personal, and connected to my lived experiences. It captures the intensity of my struggles—the disregard from my *Umma* [mother], the rejection by society, and the fight for survival. These are my memories and my truths. I felt the emotional weight in the lines about being called a "whore by my blood" and being "warned about spreading HIV." These words echo the exact phrases I've endured. The transition from pain to hope, from being judged to finding sanctuary, mirrors the ups and downs of my life. It feels reliably human and speaks to my truths. (Victory, 38yo)

The GPT-4o Poem "Beyond the Monsoon Sky" resonated with participants for its evocative imagery and thematic exploration. However, the participant reflected on its limitations and shared:

> It sounds pretty… but not like me. Like something I'd read in a book, not something I lived through. (Nila, 30yo)

This response reflects the distinction between aesthetic and experiential authenticity in narrative representation, where polished forms may resonate stylistically but fail to convey the immediacy of lived truth (Riessman, 2012). In our study, participants framed authenticity less in terms of literary refinement and more as affective immediacy, valuing raw emotional resonance over polished textual elegance. This highlights a key tension in poetic inquiry with AI: aesthetic fluency does not guarantee narrative fidelity.

> This poem is beautifully written, almost like a lyrical story, but it feels more distant from my actual experiences. The tone is softer, almost romanticized. The imagery of Kerala and the monsoons feels more like a poetic landscape than my life. It doesn't carry the same emotional weight or specificity as the first poem. The line about "a teacher's hand, amidst the darkness, a light" generalizes my actual experience. Similarly, "Family ties, once warm, now cold and severed" is true, but it doesn't cut as deep as my real experiences of rejection, like being made to sleep outside or being warned about HIV. It feels inspirational, but more like a universal tale than my personal one. (Victory, 38yo)

After individual feedback, we invited participants to engage in the collaborative poetics process through reflective discussions. Participants emphasized the value of receiving poetry as a tangible outcome of the research.

Table 5. Comparison of HGP and GPT-4o poem.

Embracing My truth | HGP	Beyond the monsoon sky: a Ballad | GPT-4o Poem
World would be wishful otherwise	In the verdant land of Kerala, where monsoons weave tales,
If people could hold with	A soul embarks on a journey, against the harsh gales.
the basic facts of existence	Born into a world that sees but does not perceive,
that, we are all different	A heart that beats tenderly, in hope and in grief.
Everything starts from this darkness …	Once a child amidst play, innocence in her eyes,
Every intolerance!	No shadows of difference, under the wide skies.
This pricks me forever, within,	But as years unfurled like the petals of a flower,
the disregard of my Umma	The world's colors changed, from sweet to sour.
Often, I daydream the day	High school brought storms, emotions deep and wild,
she accepts me, as her daughter	A yearning for love, the heart of a child.
though I can frame how shattered she is	Bullied and scorned for the softness of her voice,
the strong, masculine breadwinner of the home,	Yet, within her, a resilient spirit made its choice.
growing hair, wearing salwar kameez and sarees	A teacher's hand, amidst the darkness, a light,
Here I am, an entirely different person	A beacon of hope in the longest of nights.
Miles apart from her cognition!	Yet friends turned foes, and whispers grew loud,
My past still dwells within me	A showpiece, they said, in the merciless crowd.
For it was not so long	Family ties, once warm, now cold and severed,
The bullying, harassment, abuse, backstabbing	Her truth anathema, her existence levered.
I went through it all	From the sanctity of home to a rock then a cell,
The days I was made to sleep outside my home	In solitude and scorn, where her tears fell.
On a rock, on the bathroom floor	
The day I was called a whore by my blood	Yet, amid the tumult of fear and disdain,
The day I was warned about spreading HIV	A vision persisted, through the pain.
The many days I survived with just water	Transwomen on screens, in colors so bright,
Like yesterday!	A future envisaged, beyond the night.
The stumbling blocks that I tripped upon everyday	Chased by the shadows of an unkind society,
The constant hunt for a corner to lie down	A home, a job, peace of mind,
The constant pursuit of an occupation to survive	Elusive dreams, for a soul so true,
He came as an answer to all my seeking	In a world that judges by a view askew.
When others lust after my body	But hope, like a phoenix, from ashes does rise,
All he cared about was my happiness	In the love of a partner, a soul recognizes.
Misconceptions shadow my days,	Not for the body, but for the heart within,
Yet in my dreams, I see the light,	A sanctuary was found, amidst the din.
In the mirror, I see myself,	Surgery and pain, a path chosen and trod,
within a future that feels right.	For the woman she is, beneath the façade.
Society may cast stones,	Yet not all journeys require this toll,
filling my paths with bones.	For identity lies deep within the soul.
But I am more than what they believe,	Misunderstood, maligned, yet strong and proud,
My hearts wear no deceives,	Her voice, once quiet, now clear and loud.
But with emotions shared by every soul	Creating a space, safe and serene,
Now in my sanctuary, I stand free,	A queen in her right, amidst the green.
A testament to what can be.	This tale of resilience, of love and of strife,
A life reclaimed, a newfound kiss,	A testament to the enduring power of life.
in a world remade by love.	For in her story, a truth we find,
	The beauty of acceptance, of being kind.
	In Kerala's embrace, under its sky so vast,
	A story of a future, not tethered to the past.
	For every soul deserves a chance to fly,
	Beyond the bounds of earth, into the sky.
	A journey of self, from shadow to light,
	A tale of becoming, through the darkest night.
	This is her song, a melody of self.

> These poems are not just words; they are tools we can use to express ourselves and educate others about our realities. (Faith, 21yo)

Another participant articulated the empowering aspect of co-authorship in poetic inquiry:

> For the first time, I feel like someone wrote with me, not just about me. (Promise, 30yo)

This reflection highlights how collaborative poetics functions as a form of participatory meaning-making. Such practices resonate with critical pedagogy and feminist epistemologies, which emphasize voice, agency, and knowledge co-production as tools to resist marginalization (Hooks, 2014; Lather, 1991). In this sense, poetic inquiry not only documents experience but also becomes an emancipatory act, enabling transfeminine participants to reclaim narrative authority and challenge transphobia through creative expression.

> They might make someone pause and realize they're not alone. AI poetry brings a fresh perspective and accessibility to our stories. (Joy, 28yo)

> If parents of trans children read this, maybe they'd understand what their child is going through and how to support them better. (Grace, 25yo)

Participants envisioned the poems as tools for advocacy, sensitization, and community dialogues.

> These poems can be read in workshops, at events, or even in classrooms. They're not just stories - they're voices of survival and resilience. (Promise, 30yo)

After reviewing the poems, the participants addressed ambiguities, clarified meanings, and gave suggestions for improved clarity in certain instances. For example, in "Embracing My Truth," the opening stanza was adjusted to emphasize that transfeminine are not merely waiting for violence but are specifically targeted because of their appearance. Similarly, participants requested that certain phrases be retained in their original form, as translations would dilute their meaning. The reflections went beyond feedback on the poems. Participants shared how the process of reading these works brought unresolved emotions to the surface and opened a space for dialogue about their lived realities.

> Reading these poems felt like peeling back layers of myself. It brought up so many buried feelings but also gave me a sense of validation. (Liberty, 37yo)

Engaging with poems prompted a range of emotions from validation upon hearing their experiences reflected to detachment and frustration. Some participants expressed discomfort with AI attempting to replicate their personal narratives. Concerns were raised about the potential for misrepresentation and the ethical implications in sensitive contexts.

"Sometimes I worry … if I give my story, the AI might take the parts where I struggled and make it sound like that's all I am. Like it will just reinforce what society already thinks about people like me." (Ananya, 29yo).

> Is it right for a machine to tell our stories? It feels like it takes something deeply personal and turns it into something detached and mechanical. (Joy, 28yo)

> It feels like it's translating something it doesn't fully grasp. (Justice, 28yo)

These anxieties resonate with critiques of technological mediation in marginalized storytelling, where algorithms risk flattening lived complexity into reductive tropes (Benjamin, 2019; S. U. Noble, 2018). As participants feared, AI's tendency to foreground struggle over resilience illustrates how data-driven systems often amplify preexisting stereotypes rather than disrupt them. This tension highlights the need for what Nick Couldry and Ulises Mejias (2020) term "data colonialism" vigilance; remaining alert to how personal narratives, once fed into machine systems, may be reconfigured in ways that reproduce dominant power relations instead of affirming subaltern voices.

A related concern was voiced by another participant, who questioned AI's emotional legitimacy:

> Machines don't cry. They don't feel rejection. So how can they really write our pain? (Liberty, 37yo)

Taken together, these reflections foreground the ethics of representation, ownership, and affective labor: who gets to narrate, on what terms, and with whose consent. Feminist and decolonial perspectives caution against ventriloquizing subaltern experience and argue for data justice practices including consent, accountability, and community control over how stories are collected and reused (Alcoff, 1991; D'Ignazio & Klein, 2020; Mohanty, 1988; Neusiedler, 2024; Spivak, 1994; Tuck, 2009). In our setting, this implies treating AI outputs as comparative prompts rather than authoritative accounts, and centering participant governance over the forms, contexts, and futures of their narratives.

Overall, participants evaluated the collaborative poetics strand as innovative, affirming, and impactful. This accords with research showing that arts-based methods in general (Barnes, 1968; Walker, 2005) and poetry in particular (McPherson & Mazza, 2014; Schumer, 2018) support identity work, recognition, and belonging among marginalized groups. In our setting, returning the poems to participants for joint interpretation reframed relationships between researchers and participants, foregrounding reciprocity, respect, and shared ownership. Participants described the poems as giving language to difficult experiences and as resources for advocacy, sensitization, and community dialogue. Consistent with Priyanka Aiyer (2020), poetry here functioned as both method and outcome, enabling transfeminine participants to articulate their trans identity through collective reflection and voice. At the same time,

several tensions remained. For some participants, revisiting condensed accounts of harm was emotionally taxing. Poetic transcription and translation involve curatorial decisions about selection, sequencing, and Malayalam-English rendering that can reshape voice despite member checking. Wider circulation also raises risks to confidentiality and context. Finally, AI mediated texts, though useful as comparative prompts, can encode dominant stereotypes and shift affective labor back onto participants.

6. Comparing HGPs with GPT-4o poems

In this study, human-generated poems (HGPs) resonated more deeply with participants due to their groundedness in lived experience, emotional immediacy, and cultural specificity. Participants repeatedly identified the HGPs as more authentic and affecting, reflecting a nuanced embodiment of pain, resilience, and identity formation. Because HGPs were written by insider researchers who share language and context with participants, part of this advantage plausibly reflects author-community proximity rather than "humanness" alone. A useful counterfactual for future work is an outsider-poet condition (matched on craft credentials) to test whether proximity or technique better predicts higher ratings on Emotional Quality and Atmosphere. This distinction clarifies that some of the observed "human advantage" may actually be a proximity (insider-author) effect rather than humanness per se, a point we return to in the Limitations.

By contrast, GPT-4o poems were frequently described as stylistically cohesive yet emotionally distant or romanticized, especially when rendering trauma or systemic violence. Victory (38) remarked that the AI poem was *"beautifully written, almost like a lyrical story, but… more like a poetic landscape than my life,"* while Faith (21) felt it was *"polished, almost wise,"* in ways that reduced trust. This pattern echoes critiques that computational creativity tends to generalize affect and miss embodied subjectivity (Boden, 2016; Colton & Wiggins, 2012). It also aligns with audience-reception research showing that formal fluency can mask affective thinness (Porter & Machery, 2024). The quantitative results mirror these judgements: with authorship masked and order randomized, median ratings showed HGPs > AI on Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, and Structural Quality, while Creativity exhibited overlap across conditions. Exploratory mixed-effects models likewise indicated positive human-authorship coefficients on these dimensions, with Emotional Quality and Atmosphere the strongest predictors of perceived authenticity. In short, participants did not simply reward polish; they rewarded poems that felt emotionally resonant and thematically coherent within their lived worlds. Participants also articulated ethical concerns about representation. Several worried that making their narratives maximally legible to a model could enable misclassification, stereotype drift, or extractive reuse outside their control, reiterating warnings about epistemic erasure and datafied harms in socio-technical systems (S. U. Noble, 2018). For creative text specifically, recent analyses suggest that AI-generated poetry often flattens culturally embedded metaphors and local symbolism into generic tropes (Deng et al., 2024; Opaluwah, 2025). This not only erases nuance but risks reinscribing the very stereotypes participants resist. In response, this study advances bounded legibility: co-creating texts that remain interpretable to intended audiences while preserving protective ambiguity around details that, if over-exposed, could lead to harm, misappropriation, or reductive categorization.

Importantly, the stylistic polish that participants noticed (regular rhythms, universal metaphors, narrative closure) plausibly reflects the prompted style as much as the model. A different constraint set (e.g., contemporary spoken-word cadence; elliptical or fragmentary lineation; image-driven, culturally specific diction) might raise Emotional Quality and Atmosphere while trading off some Structural Quality. For that reason, these results should be read as perceptions of a specific model and prompt configuration, not a blanket verdict on "AI poetry." Accordingly, poem reception is prompt-contingent; the estimates reported here generalize to GPT-4o under the neutral-lyric template (Appendix D), not to AI poetry in general; we elaborate design consequences in Section 6.1. Two design implications follow. First, affective fidelity (capturing emotional texture, pacing, and vulnerability) should be treated as a core target when evaluating AI-assisted poetic outputs in sensitive domains, alongside fluency and coherence. The four-factor instrument (see Table 3) provides a compact way to operationalize that target. Second, prompt provenance matters; reporting prompt style, constraints, and parameters clarifies authorship as a composite of model and instruction by enabling fairer comparison and replication.

Finally, the comparative findings underscore different strengths. HGPs excelled in conveying complexity through situated detail and tonal grain, features participants linked to credibility and care. GPT-4o, even when admired for surface cohesion, struggled to sustain affective alignment with lived experience, particularly around scenes of violence and family rejection. Participant's feedback—"not like my life," "polished but hard to trust," captures the gap between aesthetic admiration and experiential authenticity that current models have yet to close. This gap is not merely technical; it is socio-cultural. Without community-governed aims and protective editorial choices, attempts to make marginalized experience maximally legible to generative systems can collapse context and amplify risk. Our comparative analysis therefore supports a practical stance: use AI cautiously as a supplementary instrument within co-creative, community-led poetics, organized around bounded legibility and affective fidelity, rather than as a surrogate for human articulation of suffering and resilience.

6.1. Design implications for AI-mediated poetics

Our findings suggest that perceived authenticity in AI-mediated poetry is anchored less in surface craft than in affective fidelity; the preservation of cadence, idiom, and the situated textures of harm and hope that participants recognize as their own. This resonates with recent work in creative AI and HCI that treats authenticity as a relational quality grounded in voice, agency, and liveness, rather than as a purely formal property of the output (Holopainen et al., 2025). Designing for affective fidelity therefore implies privileging insider or community-proximate curation of source excerpts, resisting prompts that globalize metaphors or romanticize trauma, and accepting a degree of roughness where polish would erase experiential particularity.

At the same time, our reception results are prompt-contingent, wherein style constraints shape judgments even when the model and data are held constant. In line with provenance-oriented approaches to AI creativity, we treat the prompt family itself as a first-class design artifact whose identity and evolution should be made inspectable (e.g., via versioned templates, IDs, and minimal run logs). Publishing the neutral-lyric template we used (Appendix D) is not only a transparency measure; it enables cumulative inquiry by letting others reproduce or deliberately vary the constraint set to probe how different prompt families (spoken-word cadence, elliptical lineation, image-dense local diction) shift affective and structural outcomes (Garcia, 2025).

Transparency toward audiences also matters. Prior work shows that perceptions of authenticity and trust are shaped by how creative process is disclosed; process-based credentials (what was used, how, and by whom) are often more useful than binary "AI/not-AI" labels, and harm-based warnings are best reserved for contexts where misrecognition risks are high (Brüns & Meißner, 2024; Burrus et al., 2024). For community-facing poetry, lightweight provenance labels alongside each poem (e.g., "HGP, insider-authored, member-checked" or "GPT-4o, neutral-lyric template, no post-edit") allow readers to calibrate expectations without overloading them, while preserving bounded-legibility for sensitive excerpts.

A further implication concerns human-AI role design. Evidence from consumer and brand-authenticity research indicates that fully automated generation can depress perceived authenticity, whereas assistive or co-creative use, where humans remain visibly responsible for selection, sequencing, and ethical governance, attenuates that penalty (Brüns & Meißner, 2024). Our results align with this pattern of participants crediting insider authorship and member-checking for emotional resonance and treating AI outputs as comparative stimuli rather than authoritative narratives. In practice, this argues for "AI-assisted, human-led" workflows in sensitive cultural domains by declaring the human role (curation, line resequencing, member-checking), keeping AI outputs output-fixed for evaluation, and by centering community governance over what remains deliberately opaque.

Finally, design and evaluation should separate aesthetic from experiential authenticity. The paradox noted in AI scholarship that technical fluency can rise as human meaning thins also appears in our data as higher perceived polish for some GPT-4o poems alongside lower ratings for Emotional Quality and Atmosphere. We therefore recommend reporting dual scorecards: one for surface craft (readability/flow, lineation, closure) and one for experiential fit (voice, specificity, situatedness), accompanied by a brief curator note on what was preserved versus smoothed. This dual reporting makes explicit the

tradeoffs that prompt families introduce and aligns evaluation with the values of recognition, agency, and safety. This could ultimately motivate AI-mediated poetics in marginalized contexts.

7. Limitations and suggestions for future research

A key limitation of this study lies in its geographically bounded and demographically specific focus. While purposive sampling ensured the inclusion of transfeminine individuals with diverse lived experiences, the study was situated within the socio-cultural context of Kerala. The findings do not seek statistical generalizability; instead, they aim for transferability, allowing readers to judge whether the insights inform similar contexts. The inherently interpretive nature of poetic inquiry means participant responses varied widely, given the subjectivity of poetry reception. Poem quality and authorship judgements are prompt-family dependent. Our findings should therefore be read as specific to GPT-4o and the neutral-lyric template (Appendix D). Different prompt families (e.g., spoken-word cadence; fragmentary lineation; image-driven diction) will likely shift factor scores, especially Structural Quality and Atmosphere and may narrow or widen the human-AI gap. This has three consequences: (i) replicability (studies should publish prompt templates and lock them before data collection) (ii) comparability (results should be framed as *model-and-prompt* outcomes rather than "AI poetry" in the abstract) and (iii) design (future work should factorize prompt families (neutral-lyric vs spoken-word, etc.) and pre-register contrasts to test how style constraints mediate Emotional Quality and perceived authenticity). We also recommend reporting a short 'prompt audit (template ID, lock date, and any edits) alongside model details to support cumulative science. Results should also be read as specific to the model-and-prompt configuration under the neutral-lyric template in Appendix D and may differ under alternative prompt families. Our reliance on non-expert readers, while appropriate for community-based research, may have shaped evaluations differently than those of literary scholars, poets, or cultural theorists. Future studies can stratify reader expertise to compare how each group weights Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, Creativity, and Structural Quality.

We did not include a human outsider-poet comparison matched by craft credentials. As a result, some of the observed advantage for HGPs may reflect insider authorship and author-community proximity rather than "human vs AI" status alone. To disaggregate insider-author proximity from human vs AI status, a concrete next step is a 2×2 design: *Authorship* (Human, AI) $\times$ *Proximity* (Insider, Outsider). Human-Insider poems (our HGPs) are authored by researchers/community-adjacent insiders; Human-Outsider poems can be authored by poets matched on craft credentials but without community proximity, using the same excerpt, constraints, and output-fixed policy. Pre-registered contrasts should test: (i) Insider $>$ Outsider on Emotional/Atmosphere (a proximity effect among humans); (ii) Human-Outsider $>$ AI to isolate the residual humanness effect once proximity is removed; and (iii) whether Structural/Creativity advantages are driven by style constraints rather than proximity. Collecting a single-item perceived proximity rating for each poem (e.g., "feels close to a lived experience like mine/ours") enables covariate or mediation analyses to estimate how much of the human advantage is explained by proximity. Power can be planned on the authorship-by-proximity interaction in a mixed-effects framework (items and raters random). Outsider poets should be selected by craft-matched portfolio review, given the same masked excerpts and prompt constraints, and required to follow a no post-editing rule. To preserve comparability, we recommend identical neutral-lyric constraints for the first pass, followed by a registered style-variant follow-up if needed. In sum, the next study should factorize proximity and humanness. Demonstrating Human-Outsider $>$ AI would support a genuine humanness advantage; Human-Insider $>$ Human-Outsider would quantify the added value of author-community proximity.

On the AI side, poems were produced via the standard GPT-4o interface using short, de-identified excerpts. Retention/training settings were not configurable and rare-attribute combinations were not systematically suppressed, leaving residual re-identification risk despite de-identification. To reduce this risk, future work should prefer no-retention/no-training APIs or local/on-prem models, implement multi-layer redaction (including rare-combination suppression), secure vendor-specific consent with opt-out/withdrawal rights for AI-derived text, and practice community co-governance over what remains deliberately opaque (see Appendix A for a consolidated checklist).

Beyond implementation details, researchers should interrogate systemic risks associated with using identity-based narratives in generative systems, including data commodification, cultural misrepresentation, and epistemic violence. Methodologically, future studies should pre-register authorship and rating tasks, report parameter-level outcomes, and experimentally compare output-fixed vs editor-mediated AI poems and prompt variants to test how process choices shape perceived authenticity. In HCI contexts, pair these measures with UX constructs (e.g., trust, perceived fairness, satisfaction) and examine how results vary across prompt families and authorship-proximity conditions. Finally, multimodal extensions (text-image-audio) may enrich affective texture but heighten risks of cultural-signal leakage and re-identification. Any multimodal expansion should adopt bounded legibility and audience-scoped dissemination, with safeguards such as voice/image masking and multimodal consent flows. This layered approach, alongside the governance recommendations above, offers a pragmatic path to deepen inquiry while minimizing harm.

8. Conclusion

This study affirms a persistent distinction in contemporary creative practice. While large language models (LLMs) such as GPT-4o exhibit syntactic fluency and thematic coherence, they struggle to capture the emotional granularity, cultural embeddedness, and epistemic depth that marked participants' responses to human-generated poems (HGPs). Within HPF (Figure 1), HGPs resonated more strongly, not merely as an aesthetic preference but because they enacted affective truth-telling and narrative fidelity. As Grace (25) reflected, *"If parents of trans children read this, maybe they'd understand what their child is going through."* Taken together with other participant reflections, this shows coauthored poetry enacting epistemic justice and social recognition by making lived knowledge legible, shareable, and respected. These accounts also show art functioning as communicative intimacy, with creativity inseparable from identity and context (Barrett, 2010; Dissanayake, 1995).

Empirically, participants rated HGPs higher on Emotional Quality, Atmosphere, and Structural Quality, with Creativity the one dimension on which AI outputs occasionally matched human work. Participants frequently described AI poems as "polished" yet emotionally distant or romanticized, consistent with evidence that audiences may admire formal esthetics while sensing an absence of affective sincerity (Porter & Machery, 2024; Shen et al., 2024). These results are prompt-contingent: they generalize to GPT-4o under the neutral-lyric template documented in Appendix D, not to "AI poetry" in general.

Beyond measurement, participants' reflections align with calls to shift from data-centric toward context-centric AI that involves communities across design and interpretation (Okolo, 2023; Robles & Mallinson, 2023). When generative systems are deployed without sustained participation, they risk reproducing epistemic violence by abstracting lived experience into decontextualized and legible artifacts (Bender et al., 2021; B. Noble, 2013). In response, this study positions AI not as an authorial surrogate but as a supplementary instrument within human-led, community-anchored storytelling practices. Such an orientation demands careful curation of source material, preservation of cadence and idiom, transparent disclosure of prompt provenance, and evaluative attention to affective fidelity alongside surface craft (Birhane & Prabhu, 2021). Under these conditions, AI can function as a comparative or reflective device without displacing participant voice or narrative authority.

Our findings also crystallize a central design tension in AI-mediated creativity: aesthetic fluency does not equate to experiential authenticity. While current LLMs readily produce formal polish and narrative closure, these qualities alone do not secure emotional depth, cultural resonance, or trust. We therefore argue that prompt families should be treated as first-class design artifacts whose constraints and stylistic commitments are made inspectable, versioned, and accountable. Audience-facing process labels (e.g., *insider-authored, member-checked* vs *LLM-generated, output-fixed*) can further support situated trust by allowing readers to calibrate expectations without collapsing complex creative processes into binary human/AI distinctions (Burrus et al., 2024; Garcia, 2025; Holopainen et al., 2025). Looking forward, we call for pre-registered designs that disentangle author-community proximity from humanness (Human/AI × Insider/Outsider), systematically vary prompt families, and prioritize no-retention or on-prem deployments where feasible. Taken together, these directions outline a reproducible and ethically

grounded pathway for community-governed AI-mediated poetics, one that respects lived specificity, sustains epistemic justice, and enables cumulative inquiry.

Notes

1. Research poetry refers to the use of poetic form as a qualitative research tool, where lines and imagery are drawn from participant data to evoke meaning and emotion while maintaining integrity to the source narratives.
2. Yan's framework allowed users to input thematic keywords, which the model would iteratively revise through multiple passes, each time aligning output more closely to the specified theme.
3. A Shakespearean sonnet is a 14-line poem written in iambic pentameter with a distinct ABAB CDCD EFEF GG rhyme scheme, concluding with a rhyming couplet.
4. Originally proposed by Alan Turing in 1950, the Turing Test is a method of evaluating a machine's ability to exhibit intelligent behavior indistinguishable from that of a human. In its classic form, a human evaluator interacts with both a machine and a human through a text interface; if the evaluator cannot reliably distinguish between them, the machine is considered to have passed the test. Within this study, the term is used less to assess intelligence and more to explore whether AI-generated poems can emulate human affect and authenticity in narrating transfeminine experiences.
5. Literature experts were volunteers whose academic background was in English-literature-related majors. All remaining participants were classified as non-experts/novices.
6. Human-in-the-loop refers to AI-generated content that has been reviewed, edited, or partially co-authored by a human before presentation.
7. Human-out-of-the-loop refers to AI-generated content presented without any human editing or involvement after generation.
8. Neural style transfer repurposes deep-learning models to separate "content" from "style"; an AI model learns latent style vectors from a reference author or corpus and then re-generates new sentences whose semantic content is preserved while their diction, rhythm, and other stylistic cues emulate the target tradition.
9. Macroaggressions refer to overt, large-scale discriminatory actions or structural harms, in contrast to microaggressions, which are more subtle and often interpersonal in nature.

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Ethical approval

All procedures involving human participants were conducted in accordance with the ethical standards of the Ethics Committee of St. Joseph's College, Devagiri, and in compliance with the principles of the 1964 Declaration of Helsinki and its subsequent amendments or comparable ethical standards. Prior to participation, all participants reviewed ethics-approved documentation and provided written informed consent, confirming their understanding of voluntary participation, data confidentiality, and anonymization procedures. The study design incorporated appropriate safeguards, including psychological screening and clearly communicated opt-out mechanisms, to minimize potential distress throughout the research process.

Authors contributions

CRediT: **Neerej Dev**: Conceptualization, Data curation, Formal analysis, Methodology, Software, Visualization, Writing – original draft; **Silpa Joy**: Conceptualization, Formal analysis, Investigation, Project administration, Resources, Validation, Writing – review & editing.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

AI statement

GPT-4o was used solely to generate the AI-authored poems (GPT-4o Poems) that served as stimuli in the study, following the fixed, de-identified protocol detailed in the Methods section. All other aspects of the research, including study design, data collection, analysis, interpretation, and manuscript preparation, were conducted and authored by the human researchers.

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Data availability statement

The qualitative data generated during this study are not publicly available due to participant anonymity and ethical restrictions. Summary data may be available from the authors upon reasonable request.

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Appendix A: Field-level guidance for AI assisted poetic inquiry

A practical checklist for designing, running, and publishing studies that use AI with sensitive qualitative materials. Poems were generated via the GPT-4o web interface; provider-side "no-retention/no-training" controls were not exposed and therefore were not enabled. Compensating safeguards appear in Sections 1–2, 4–8.

1) Planning and governance

- Define scope: what AI will do (e.g., draft poems from de-identified excerpts) and will not do (no full-transcript uploads; no raw identifiers).
- No-AI gate: don't proceed if de-identification/bounded legibility can't plausibly reduce re-ID or cultural harm.
- Community oversight: convene an advisory group; minute decisions on prompts, redactions, dissemination scope.
- Risk register/DPIA: log privacy (re-ID, context collapse), representation, and secondary-use risks with mitigations.
- Reproducibility: pin model/version; record temperature, top-p, max tokens, seed; decide how to handle non-determinism.

2) Data minimizations and transformation

- Excerpt-only: upload short, de-identified segments; never full transcripts.
- Paraphrase rule: prefer paraphrase/summaries unless participants request verbatim for voice fidelity.
- Rare-combo rule: suppress/generalize attribute combos in <2 participants or $<5\%$ of corpus (e.g., job-place-event triads; exact dates $\rightarrow$ month/season).
- Translation protocol: Malayalam $\leftrightarrow$ English via dual independent translators + adjudication; back-translation for culturally marked terms; maintain a participant-approved glossary.

3) Infrastructure and vendor settings

- Model choice & retention status: If possible, use no-retention/no-training APIs or local/on-prem models. If using the consumer ChatGPT web UI (as in this study), note explicitly that provider-side no-retention/no-training controls were not exposed and thus not enabled.
- Processor & DPA: Treat the vendor as a data processor; execute a DPA; note cross-border transfers (e.g., SCCs); record that internal provider handling cannot be technically verified when using the consumer UI.
- Security: encryption in transit/at rest; role-based access; secret management (vaulted), not in docs. Proceed only where co-creative/empirical value is substantial and the safeguards in Section 1–2, 4–9 are in place; cross-reference Section 5.4 in the main text.

4) Prompting and logging

- Template prompts: version-controlled, pre-approved by advisory group.
- Pre-prompt redaction: automatic PII/rare-combo scan + manual review.
- Local run-log: {timestamp, user, model + version, temperature, top-p, max_tokens, seed, prompt_template_id, excerpt_hash, output_hash, purpose}; store encrypted.
- Retention note: Include a field vendor_retention_controls="not available/not enabled (ChatGPT web)" to make parameter opacity/constraints auditable.
- Data hygiene: don't paste prompts/outputs into third-party collaboration tools.

5) Consent and participant communication

- Vendor-specific consent: Name model/provider; describe data flow and state clearly whether provider no-retention/no-training controls are available/enabled; explain residual risks in plain language.
- Opt-out/withdrawal: offer both; allow removal of AI-derived text at any time.
- Benefit sharing: return poems for advocacy; honoraria for member-checking.
- Contact & SLA: provide contact route and 14-day withdrawal closure target.

6) Generation protocol

- Upload hygiene: confirm no identifiers/full transcripts/rare combos before every run.
- Output policy: use output-fixed when authorship/ratings are outcomes; if editing is allowed, keep an edit ledger (who/what/why) and state authorship implications.
- Provenance: maintain secure mapping from excerpt → output (hash-based) for audit/withdrawal.

7) Post-generation review and member-checking

- Member-checking: validate accuracy, tone, cultural cues; apply bounded legibility edits before any sharing.
- Trauma-informed: offer breaks, skip rights, support contacts.
- Disagreement handling: document on how conflicts are resolved; privilege participant safety.

8) Dissemination and bounded legibility

- Audience scoping: tailor quoted detail to venue; avoid publishing prompts/excerpts enabling re-ID.
- Composite use: prefer composite/synthetic examples for methods illustration where granular detail adds risk.
- Ethics note: add a short rationale for bounded legibility (harm minimization > maximal transparency).
- Re-use policy: specify distribution scope; apply no-training/no-derivatives license; disclose AI-assistance/provenance where appropriate.

9) Archiving and repository policy

- Share: schematics, codebooks, item mappings, analysis code.
- Withhold: verbatim prompts/excerpts and provenance linkage tables.
- Documentation: include data dictionary + environment file (requirements.txt/session Info).
- Storage & retention: encrypted, access-controlled institutional storage; define retention period and destruction schedule.

10) Withdrawal and deletion workflow

- Lookup table: maintain secure participant → artifact links.
- Process: on withdrawal, remove items from datasets, figures, appendices, and supplements; log actions; confirm completion within 14 days.

- Incident response: on leakage/misuse, notify PI/ethics, execute takedown, inform affected participants, document remediation.

Reporting checklist (Methods/Ethics)

- Model/tool: name, version, interface; parameters (temperature, top-p, max tokens, seed); prompt style/template (redacted if needed).
- Uploaded text: excerpt scope, de-ID steps, paraphrase vs verbatim rule, rare-combo threshold.
- Retention/training: vendor retention status; mitigations if not configurable.
- Consent/withdrawal: options provided; uptake (if relevant); SLA met.
- Member-checking/bounded legibility: changes made and why.
- Analysis: CI method (e.g., Clopper-Pearson); random-effects structure (participants and poems); preregistration status; exploratory framing.
- Repository policy: what was shared/withheld and rationale; environment file included.
- Consistency: use "participant judgment" (not "label"); standardize numerics (e.g., 0.50 chance line); state model-plus-prompt authorship stance.
- Vendor retention status: e.g., "No provider-side no-retention/no-training controls were available in the ChatGPT web interface; none were enabled."

Appendix B: Statistical transparency and software environment

Authorship accuracy. Exact Clopper-Pearson 95% CIs; $n = 200$, correct $k = 124$. With balanced classes, accuracy = balanced accuracy; chance = 0.50.

Signal detection (SDT). Log-linear (Hautus) correction (+0.5 to each confusion-matrix cell). AUC computed from d′ as $AUC = \Phi(d'/\sqrt{2})$, where Φ is the standard normal CDF. Bootstrap CIs for SDT metrics: B = 10,000 resamples; percentile intervals; seed = 42.

GLM (authorship vs chance). Python 3.11; statsmodels 0.14.1; binomial logistic; cluster-robust SEs (cluster = participant); two-tailed $\alpha = 0.05$.

GLMM (authorship vs chance). R 4.3.2; lme4 1.1–35.1; binomial logit; optimizer = bobyqa; random intercepts for participant and poem; two-tailed $\alpha = 0.05$.

Ratings models (Figure 4; Table 4). Linear mixed-effects with random intercepts for participant and poem; fixed effects for Authorship, Framing (Human, AI; ref = Nothing), and Authorship × Framing. Report marginal and conditional R^2.

Randomization/masking. Poem order randomized within participant; authorship masked; framing assigned independently of true authorship at the trial level. A trial-order covariate was included in a sensitivity model (no effect).

Key packages. Python: NumPy 1.26, SciPy 1.11, pandas 2.1, statsmodels 0.14.1, matplotlib 3.10.5. R: lme4 1.1–35.1, broom.mixed 0.2.9.

Reproducibility. Session details and dependency lists provided (R sessionInfo(), Python requirements.txt). Seeds: 42 (bootstrap); randomization seeds recorded in the analysis script.

Appendix C: Glossary

Table C1. Glossary of key terms.

Term	Meaning
Umma	"mother" (colloquial, Malayalam)
salwar kameez	a type of suit, worn especially by Asian women, with loose trousers and a long shirt
saree	a dress, worn especially by South Asian women, consisting of a very long piece of thin cloth wrapped around the body

Appendix D: Prompt template

Used for all GPT-4o generations in Phase Two. We follow a bounded-legibility policy: the template is published verbatim, while participant text is not; the slot below uses a placeholder.

Compose a short free-verse poem from a de-identified first-person narrative excerpt.

Constraints:

- Length: 12–24 lines; avoid long stanzas.
- Form: clear line breaks; natural cadence; no rhyme scheme unless it emerges naturally.
- Voice fidelity: preserve the speaker's rhythms, pauses, syntax, and diction. Do not add events or imagery not implied by the excerpt.

- Content limits: do not include names, specific places, addresses, institutions, clinic names, or dates. No caste/community labels or medical details unless already broadly implied.
- Tone: grounded, immediate, non-romanticized; avoid stock "inspirational" phrasing and universalizing metaphors.
- Devices: you may use repetition, spacing, and enjambment to carry affect.
- Person: keep the speaker's person if present; do not switch to third person.

Output:

- Title on the first line (5–8 words, plain).
- Then the poem only (no explanation).

Theme Tags <*placeholder*>*: e.g., transitioning, violence, agency*
De-identified excerpt <*placeholder*>